

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN LEBANON

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around the lever that won the Bisri Valley — a sustained civil-society campaign that turned a project's own weaknesses (heritage, seismic danger, lost farmland, and cost) into arguments the financier could not ignore, until the World Bank withdrew its money and the project fell — and it names the tools you'll meet (the financier's exit, the heritage and seismic and agricultural case, the courts, the campaign) in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In the **Bisri Valley** south of Beirut, the state and the **World Bank** planned a **mega-dam** that would have drowned **six million square metres of fertile land** — pine and citrus groves that had cradled civilisations since the Bronze Age — and more than **fifty historical and archaeological sites**, among them a Roman temple and the Mar Moussa Church, all on an **active seismic fault**. The valley was to be sacrificed for a reservoir many argued Beirut did not even need, and could not safely hold. But Lebanese would not lose it. A sustained campaign — residents, environmentalists, heritage defenders, engineers, and civil-society groups — documented the valley's fertile land, its ancient sites, and the seismic danger, took the fight to the courts and the streets and the world's press, and pressed those arguments where they would bite hardest: on the project's financier. After years of pressure, the **World Bank cancelled its remaining funds in September 2020**, and without the money the dam fell. A campaign had beaten the government and the World Bank at once, and saved a green valley.

The Bisri Valley campaign drew on tools available to a community in Lebanon, unconventional as they are, and turned them against the government and the World Bank at once. The sharpest, in a state where the government itself cannot be relied on, is the **financier's exit**: an accountable backer — a development bank, a foreign lender — can be made to withdraw, and without its money the project falls, as the World Bank's withdrawal felled the Bisri dam. What makes that possible is the project's own weaknesses, turned into the case against it and aimed where they bite hardest, at the money — the **heritage and archaeological value**, the **seismic danger**, and the **lost farmland** are powerful, project-killing arguments. And the **courts** can be used, if slowly; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. All of it is carried by a sustained civil-society campaign across residents, experts, and heritage and environmental groups. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The win came **not through Lebanon's own institutions but through an external financier** — because the state was too captured and dysfunctional to stop its own project, the lever that worked was the Bank's exit, and a project funded domestically or by a less accountable backer would be far harder. Lebanon's **governance is deeply dysfunctional and sectarian**, its institutions weak and often captured, so domestic remedies are unreliable and the courts slow. And the country's **overlapping crises** — economic collapse, political paralysis — make sustained organising hard. So aim for what this lever can deliver by finding the pressure point (often the money, often outside a captured state) and pressing it relentlessly.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A mega-project backed by the state and a global bank looks unstoppable in a captured country, but it depends on money and permissions with weak points, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Lebanese fight turns on the **financier's exit**; on the **heritage, seismic, and agricultural case** that makes a project indefensible; on the **courts**; and on a **sustained public campaign**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the financier's money, in a state that cannot stop its own project, is often the one that breaks it. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months — or years — on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the state cannot be moved, aim at the money** — Bisri fell not because Lebanon stopped it, but because the World Bank withdrew.
- **If the project has an accountable financier, that's your sharpest lever** — a development bank can be made to answer for heritage, safety, and cost.
- **If it threatens heritage, safety, or farmland, those are project-killing arguments** — the Roman temple, the seismic fault, the ancient groves made Bisri indefensible.
- **If governance is captured and the courts slow, expect a long, external fight** — the win took years and turned on a backer outside the captured state.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **find the pressure point a captured state can't protect — usually the financier's money, and arm it with the heritage, seismic, and agricultural case, the courts, and a sustained campaign**. That's how Bisri was saved.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and where its weak point is.

Who Actually Decides

Formally, the **state** approves and drives the project — but in Lebanon the state is often captured and dysfunctional, so it cannot be relied on to stop its own scheme. The real weak point is frequently the **financier** — a development bank or foreign lender, accountable in ways the state is not, whose money the project cannot survive without. The **courts** exist but are slow. And the **heritage, seismic, and agricultural** facts are arguments that can make a project indefensible. Know which of these you can reach — the financier's money is often the sharpest.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The financing. The project depends on a financier's money (as Bisri depended on the World Bank). *Your opening — the decisive one:* make the financier withdraw by making the money indefensible.

The approvals. *Your opening:* the heritage, seismic, and agricultural failings that should bar approval.

The courts. *Your opening:* a legal challenge, slow but real.

The public campaign. *Your opening:* the sustained campaign of residents, experts, and heritage and environmental groups that carries it all.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who finances it** — the development bank, the lender, the state budget — because an accountable financier is often the weak point, as the World Bank was. **What indefensible harms it does** — the lost heritage, the seismic danger, the sacrificed farmland, the dubious cost — the arguments that make the money impossible to keep spending. **What the project truly is** — whether it's even needed or safe — because a project that doesn't add up is one a financier can be made to abandon.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **financier** (a development bank, a lender) can be made to withdraw and is often more accountable than the state. The **courts** can be used, if slowly. **Heritage and antiquities authorities** and **seismic and environmental experts** supply the project-killing facts. And Lebanon's **residents, environmentalists, heritage defenders, engineers, and civil-society groups** are the forces that reach furthest — the sustained campaign that beat the government and the World Bank at once.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, in a captured and crisis-ridden state. What most moves them: whether there's an accountable financier, whether the harms are indefensible, and whether the campaign can be sustained.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Make an accountable financier withdraw	35–60%	years	low–mod	A project starved of funds (Bisri)
Raise the heritage / seismic / farmland case	30–55%	months–yr	low	Arguments that make it indefensible
Court challenge	15–40%	1–3 yr	mod	A decision delayed or quashed (slowly)
Sustained civil-society campaign	30–55%	years	low	A national and international cause
Domestic-institution remedies alone	10–30%	slow	low	Unreliable — the state is captured
International attention	30–55%	years	low	Pressure on the financier and the world
Everything together (financier + case + courts + campaign)	40–65%	years	mod	A project stopped (as Bisri fell)
Where the money is domestic / unaccountable	15–35%	years	mod	Harder — no external lever to pull

The levers that move the needle most are the **financier's exit** and the **heritage, seismic, and agricultural case** that forces it, backed by the **courts** and a **sustained campaign**. Bisri shows the ceiling (a mega-dam beaten by making the World Bank withdraw) and the honest floor (the win came through an external financier, not Lebanon's captured institutions, and a domestically-funded project would be far harder). So aim for a financier's money withdrawn, a project starved, and a valley or site saved — by finding and pressing the pressure point.

On cost: raising the heritage and seismic case, the campaign, and pressing the financier cost mainly organised, expert effort; litigation costs more and is slow. The great strength is that an accountable financier can be moved where a captured state cannot; the great requirement is to find that pressure point — often the money, often outside the state — and press it relentlessly through crises.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this financier, this heritage site, this seismic fault — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who finances it? Name the project, and — crucially — **who funds it**: a development bank, a foreign lender, the state budget. **An accountable financier is often your sharpest lever**, as the World Bank was at Bisri.

2. What indefensible harms does it do? The **lost heritage and archaeology, the seismic danger, the sacrificed farmland, the dubious cost** — the project-killing arguments that made Bisri indefensible.

3. Is it even needed or safe? Whether the project adds up — a reservoir Beirut may not need, on a fault it cannot safely hold — because a project that doesn't add up is one a financier can abandon.

4. What stage is it at, and where's the weak point? Financing not yet secured or reviewable, an approval pending, a court opening — and, above all, the **financier's money** you can make indefensible.

5. Who's your coalition? The **residents, environmentalists, heritage defenders, engineers, and civil-society groups** who sustained the Bisri campaign.

What this looks like in real life. A mega-project backed by the state and a development bank threatens heritage, safety, and farmland, in a country too captured to stop its own scheme. The five questions yield: the state and the financing bank (the weak point); the lost heritage, the seismic fault, the sacrificed groves (the indefensible harms); a project that may not even be needed; the financier's money as the pressure point; and a coalition of residents and experts. That's the Bisri pattern — aim at the financier, arm the case with heritage and seismic and agricultural facts, and press through the courts and a sustained campaign.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a campaign that can make a financier withdraw and one that can't is proof — of harms too indefensible to fund. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the indefensible harms. Document the **heritage and archaeology** (the ancient sites, the temple, the church), the **seismic danger** (the active fault), and the **sacrificed farmland** (the fertile groves) — with expert evidence — because these are the arguments that make a financier's money impossible to keep spending.

Layer two: the case against the project itself. Document whether it's even **needed or safe** — the questionable need, the cost, the danger — so the financier sees a project that doesn't add up.

Layer three: the financing and the pressure points. Get the **financing arrangements** and the **approvals**, and map who funds it, who must answer for it, and where a court or a heritage authority can intervene. Walking to the financier, the courts, and the world with documented, indefensible harms and a project that doesn't add up is what makes the money withdraw.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The heritage and archaeology** — the ancient sites, temples, churches the project would drown.
- **The seismic danger** — the active fault and the expert warnings.
- **The sacrificed farmland** — the fertile land and groves.
- **The financing** — who funds it, and who must answer for the money.
- **The case against need and safety** — the dubious need, cost, and danger.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a sustained coalition that can press a financier for years gives you the power that beat the World Bank. Build in four moves.

Root it in the valley and its people. The Bisri campaign was rooted in the valley — its farmland, its heritage, its residents. Root the effort there, in the people and the place the project would drown.

Bring in the experts and heritage defenders. Engineers on the seismic danger, archaeologists and heritage defenders on the ancient sites, agronomists on the farmland — the experts whose evidence makes the harms indefensible to a financier.

Aim the campaign at the financier. The decisive move: press the **financier** — the development bank or lender — with the indefensible case, in the courts, and in the world's press, until the money becomes impossible to keep spending, as the World Bank's did.

Build to last through crisis. The Bisri fight took years, through Lebanon's crises. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, international allies, and the endurance to sustain a campaign — often aimed outside a captured state — through economic collapse and political paralysis.

STEP 4: THE FINANCIER, THE HERITAGE CASE & THE COURTS

Lebanon's sharpest levers reach past a captured state to the money and the facts a project cannot survive.

The Financier's Exit — the Decisive Lever

The Bisri lever: where the state cannot be relied on to stop its own project, aim at the **financier** — an accountable development bank or lender whose money the project cannot survive without — and make that money **indefensible to keep spending**, until the financier withdraws, as the World Bank cancelled its Bisri funds in September 2020. This is Lebanon's sharpest, most distinctive move.

The Heritage, Seismic, and Agricultural Case

The arguments that force the exit: the **heritage and archaeology**, the **seismic danger**, and the **sacrificed farmland** — documented by experts — make a project indefensible and a financier's money impossible to justify. Build this case as the foundation.

The Courts and the Campaign

Use the **courts**, slow but real, to challenge and delay, and a **sustained civil-society campaign** — residents, experts, heritage and environmental groups — to carry the case to the financier, the world, and the streets.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: this model works because an accountable financier can be moved where a captured state cannot — so it is far harder where the money is domestic or the backer unaccountable; Lebanon's governance is dysfunctional and sectarian, the courts slow, and the crises make organising hard. So use the levers — the financier's exit, the indefensible case, the courts, and the campaign — find the pressure point outside the captured state, and count a financier's money withdrawn, a project starved, and a valley or site saved as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it — and in Lebanon, you aim much of it at the money.

Harm becomes a reason not to fund. Not "we oppose the dam" but *"no responsible lender can fund the drowning of Bronze Age heritage on an active fault."*

A fault becomes a fatal flaw. *"This reservoir sits on a live seismic fault — it cannot safely be built or funded."*

Farmland becomes a loss no one can justify. *"Six million square metres of ancient fertile groves, drowned for a reservoir we may not even need."*

Dysfunction becomes a case for external accountability. *"The state won't stop its own project — so the financier must answer for what its money would do."*

Match it to the venue: the indefensible harms to the financier and the world's press; the seismic and heritage failings to the approvals and the courts; the questionable need and cost to the financier's own review; the whole case to a sustained public campaign.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Lebanon, international attention is a decisive lever, because the pressure point is often an external financier who answers to the world — and a captured state does not. International and heritage-minded attention makes the media front reach far.

Lead with the heritage, the fault, and the groves, not procedure. Not "the financing review was flawed" but "they would drown Bronze Age heritage and ancient groves on a live fault, for a reservoir we may not need." Use your strongest material: the ancient sites, the seismic danger, and the valley's beauty and fertility.

Work several audiences at once. Lebanese press and public build the campaign; international and heritage-world attention reaches the financier, who cannot afford to fund the indefensible. Make it easy: clear expert evidence, striking images of the valley and its sites.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can weaken an expert-driven case. And keep aiming at the pressure point — often the money — rather than exhausting the campaign against a captured state that will not move.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — To the financier (make the money indefensible).

Subject: Your funding of [project] — heritage, safety, and cost.

"We write on [project], which your institution funds. It would [drown ancient heritage / sit on an active fault / destroy fertile farmland]: [specifics]. We ask you to withdraw, as the World Bank withdrew from Bisri. [Attach expert evidence.]"

8B — Raising the heritage / archaeology case.

Subject: The heritage [project] would drown.

"We, [group], record that [project] would drown [ancient sites, temples, churches]: [specifics]. We ask the heritage authorities and the financier to weigh this and refuse. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Raising the seismic danger.

Subject: [Project] and the seismic fault.

"Engineers warn that [project] sits on an active seismic fault: [specifics]. It cannot safely be built or funded. [Attach expert evidence.]"

8D — Court challenge (to a lawyer).

Subject: Legal challenge — [project].

"We seek to challenge [project]'s [approval / EIA]: [specifics]. We ask your advice, mindful that the courts are slow. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — To heritage / archaeology bodies.

Subject: Protect [sites] from [project].

"We ask you to act to protect [heritage sites] that [project] would drown: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8F — To the state authority.

Subject: Opposition and the financier's risk — [project].

"We are the community opposing [project] at [location], which threatens [heritage, safety, farmland]. Its financier faces the same reckoning the World Bank faced at Bisri. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: They would drown Bronze Age heritage on a live fault.

"[Project] would drown [ancient heritage / fertile groves] on an active seismic fault, for [a reservoir we may not need]. We can provide the expert evidence and the valley's story. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the campaign.

Subject: Our valley — let's make its money impossible to spend.

"[Project] would drown [our valley/heritage]. At Bisri, a campaign made the World Bank withdraw and the dam fell. Let's aim at the money the same way. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — though the fight is long — do these six things, in order:

1. **Find who finances it — the accountable financier is your sharpest lever.**
2. **Document the indefensible harms — heritage, seismic danger, farmland.**
3. **Aim the case at the financier, to make the money indefensible (8A).**
4. **Raise the heritage and seismic case with the authorities (8B/8C/8E).**
5. **Use the courts to delay (8D), and a sustained campaign to carry it (8H).**
6. **Take it international — the financier answers to the world (8G).**

Even lean, those six aim at the pressure point outside a captured state — the Bisri template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Lebanon's field is tilted by a captured, dysfunctional state, so plan for it.

When the state won't stop its own project. That is the Lebanese reality — the state was captured and drove the dam. Don't exhaust yourself against it: aim at the **financier**, as the Bisri campaign did, where the money is more accountable than the state.

When governance is dysfunctional and sectarian. Institutions are weak and captured, the courts slow. Lean on the external financier, the expert-driven heritage and seismic case, and international attention, which reach past a broken state.

When the money is domestic or unaccountable. The Bisri lever worked because the financier was the accountable World Bank. Where the money is domestic or the backer unaccountable, the fight is harder — lean harder on the courts, the heritage authorities, and the public case, and look for any pressure point.

When crisis makes organising hard. Lebanon's economic collapse and paralysis strain any campaign. Build a durable core, international allies, and the endurance to sustain the fight through the crises.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Lebanon's dysfunction and sectarian capture mean that mega-projects are often shadowed by corruption and connected interests, so this matters.

How to spot it. A project pushed despite dubious need, cost, and danger; contracts and land to connected interests; the state driving a scheme that serves the few; benefits to the connected while heritage, farmland, and communities bear the cost.

Who's supposed to guard against it. An **accountable financier** (a development bank) has its own anti-corruption and safeguard rules you can invoke — often more effective than Lebanon's own. The **courts** can be used, if slowly. And Lebanon's **civil society, heritage defenders, experts, and free-ish press** —

and international attention — can expose a captured scheme.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the dubious need and cost, who benefits, what the harms are — and route serious evidence to the financier's safeguard and integrity channels, the courts, and trusted journalists, since the financier is often more answerable than the captured state. Keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect, and pair the exposure with the heritage-and-seismic case aimed at the money.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The indefensible harms build your case; the financier's exit is the decisive lever; the residents and experts are the muscle; the heritage authorities, the courts, and the campaign press it; international attention reaches the money. Together they multiply. One at a time, or aimed only at a captured state, they stall — and the fight is long.

Early on (year 1): identify the financier; document the heritage, seismic, and farmland harms; build the coalition of residents and experts.

In the thick of it (years): aim the case at the financier; raise the heritage and seismic case with the authorities; use the courts to delay; grow the campaign and international attention.

The long haul (years): press the financier until the money withdraws, as the World Bank did at Bisri; hold the line for a financier's money withdrawn, a project starved, and a valley or site saved.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Lebanon can be done even against a captured state and a global bank at once — a campaign made the World Bank withdraw its money, and the Bisri dam fell. Hold both truths. Lebanon's distinctive power is real and unconventional: where the state itself cannot be relied on to stop its own project, a sustained campaign can turn a project's own weaknesses — lost heritage, seismic danger, sacrificed farmland, and dubious cost — into arguments aimed at the financier whose money the project cannot survive without, and make that money impossible to keep spending. And the constraints are real: the win came not through Lebanon's own captured institutions but through an external, accountable financier — so a domestically-funded project would be far harder; governance is dysfunctional and sectarian, the courts slow; and overlapping crises make organising hard.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Find who finances the project — a development bank, a foreign lender — because an accountable financier is often your sharpest lever where a captured state cannot be moved. Document the indefensible harms — the Bronze Age heritage and ancient sites, the active seismic fault, the fertile groves, the dubious need and cost — with expert evidence, so the money becomes impossible to justify. Aim that case at the financier, in the courts, in the heritage authorities, and above all in the world's press, and sustain a civil-society campaign of residents, experts, and heritage and environmental defenders through Lebanon's crises. Where the money is domestic or unaccountable, be honest that the fight is harder, and press every other pressure point. Count a financier's money withdrawn, a project starved, and a valley or site saved as wins. That's how Bisri was saved — the financier's exit, forced by an indefensible heritage-and-seismic case, together. So can you.